

His friend circle had stories to tell of money multiplied in real-estate deals. He felt as if he were being left behind. His wife too kept pushing him on – we're not doing anything, everybody else is getting rich, I should have married the businessman my dad had proposed instead of 'salary class'... Anyway, *ye mutual fund shund toh amiron ka khel hai, sab ghotala hai*. And that led to a rant about the stock market and Harshad Mehta and the scams since. The conversation ends.

I usually exit a conversation when it falls to an illogical, emotional rant about unrelated issues. We forget how many of our money decisions are related to emotions, power equations within the family and suppressed issues that tend to erupt at some random trigger. So I said, whatever, not my money. Bhai goes and books the flat a week later.

Now in 2018, the flat is sucking up a chunk of his salary. He's spent another Rs 10 lakhs to do it up – state-of-the art kitchen with German hobs, Italian marble. As an aside: think about it – why would you pay for stone to be quarried in another country and shipped to become your kitchen slab when there is perfectly good stone available locally? Did it have to do with the salesman saying with a curl of the lip – we only deal in imported marble; for the Indian stuff you need to go elsewhere.

So much of our buying decisions has to do with what other people think of us. And that 15,000-rupee maintenance is just the additional expense that is slowly strangling the household budget. The rent he gets is not even half the EMI.

Bhai now begins to panic, retirement is just round the corner, and the 'always-up' real-estate market has gone into a funk. He thinks of selling. The market is flat and he's getting just about what he paid for it. *Chalo*, at least investment *to wapas aa gaye*, he told me. But what about the interest cost of the loan you took, I twist the knife. Add the ten lakhs of doing-up cost, the monthly maintenance bill, and deduct the rent from the costs, and he is staring at a loss. *Chalo ji*, long term *me saab theek ho jayega*.

He's now holding on till he makes a small profit on his investment. And all the while he's hurtling towards retirement, funnelling money in an asset that will take a long, long time to recover. He could have been funnelling it into a